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Facebook's 2015 Updated News Feed Impact on Marketers



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

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Facebook is a multi-billion dollar company because companies pay to use the platform to market their advertising messages to Facebook's [1.35 billion monthly active users](#). If there had been any confusion as to why Facebook is so profitable, 2015 appears to be the year that this becomes crystal clear.

Previously, once your company got a Facebook user to like its page, that company's messages found a home in the aggregate news feed of each fan. Your message was received indiscriminately, provided the recipient logged in to Facebook that day. But this organic reach didn't make Facebook any money.

Changes in Effect this Year

Now, organic promotional content has been targeted by Facebook's algorithm. Straightforward promotional content will be culled from most news feeds. Businesses can still use Facebook's platform to advertise, but now it's going to cost them.

A recent announcement on [Facebook's official blog](#) explains the change:

"As part of an ongoing survey, we asked hundreds of thousands of people how they feel about

the content in their News Feeds. People told us they wanted to see more stories from friends and Pages they care about, and less promotional content."

Some have come to call this the "[overly promotional](#)" penalty. It's less a penalty on an entire site like a Google penalty would constitute, but the effect is similar on each penalized post. If this has left you scratching your head, Facebook has provided common traits of organic posts it will consider too promotional:

1. Posts that solely push people to buy a product or install an app
2. Posts that push people to enter promotions and sweepstakes with no real context
3. Posts that reuse the exact same content from ads

Facebook recommends businesses see their Page "as a cornerstone of their online identity, not simply as a publishing service." This is why promotions and sweepstakes with no context to the brand's overall communication strategy will get penalized.

What this means for marketers is simple: The blatant sales pitches and promotional offers that previously appeared in the news feeds of those who liked your business will no longer reach your fans.

Facebook's intention is clear; it wants brands to engage with its audience without directly selling something. If a company wishes to present users with a straightforward sales pitch, then they will have to buy ad space from Facebook.



What's a Marketer to do?

The social media marketing website Socially Stacked provides a few [simple alternatives](#) for those who depended on Facebook's organic reach for marketing. These alternatives include:

1. **Run promotions, sweepstakes and other campaigns directly on your website.**

Socially Stacked cites a case study with ZipCar UK. The car rental service shifted its campaigns to its website and saw a dramatic shift in engagement. "They saw a 717 percent increase in entries into their web-based competition and a 204 percent increase in page visits to their promotion," says Sara at *Socially Stacked*.

2. **Use traditional media sources to distribute your promotional announcements.**

Facebook had once been a great platform for press releases. Now this seems to be less viable. However, you still have the traditional media sources to fall back on. Press release services are still around and still effective. Also, fall back on your email lists to blast the group that you know will be interested in your marketing messages.

Takeaway

It may be a bitter pill for marketers to swallow since Facebook provided a decade of free engagement between businesses and their customers. Now that Facebook is tightening the reins on free publicity, marketers need to fall back on the tried and true basics of getting the word out on their products and services.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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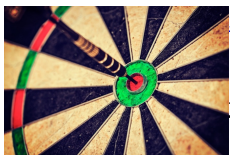
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